

Sam’s Club — Data Scientist III

Offer & Negotiation Brief | Bentonville, AR (relocation) | Prepared for Kanu Madhok

The offer on the table

Component	Offer	Note
Base	\$115,000	Guaranteed cash; drives bonus + raises
Bonus target	15% (~\$17,250)	Percentage of base
Equity (RSU)	\$50,000 / yr	Above market — leave it alone
Total comp	~\$182,250	At/above levels.fyi L3 avg, but only because equity is rich

Your strongest card: the recruiter’s own range math

The recruiter said they **typically hire 40–50% into the range**, and the band is **\$90k–\$180k**.

- Midpoint = **\$135k**; each 10% of range = \$9k. 40–50% into range = **\$126,000–\$135,000** (their stated hiring zone).
- Your \$115k offer sits at just **28% of the range** — **below** their own typical zone by \$11–20k.
- A **\$130k ask = 44% of range** (dead center). **\$135k** = the midpoint — still “middle of range,” not a reach.

Reframe: you’re not asking them to stretch — you’re asking them to honor the policy the recruiter just described. Quote it back.

Multi-source benchmark table (DS III base, current)

Source	What it says	Use
H1B / DOL LCA filings (2025)	Median base \$120k ; top filings \$130–135k	Strong
Levels.fyi — Walmart L3/P3 DS (US)	Base \$129–134k · stock ~\$32k · bonus ~\$14k · total \$175–180k	Strong
Glassdoor — Data Scientist, Bentonville	25th-pct base ~ \$123–127k (above your offer)	Strong
Glassdoor — Sam’s Club DS (19)	25th-pct \$123k → 75th-pct \$200k total	Supports
Comparably — Walmart/Sam’s DS	Base ~\$116.7k + bonus ~ \$21.3k (~18%)	Bonus lever
Glassdoor — Sam’s Club <i>Senior</i> DS	Base \$131.8k + ~\$57k = \$188.8k (level above)	Context
Indeed / ZipRecruiter / Payscale (AR)	\$91k–\$122k — blended / junior / stale	Ignore

Note: 2025 filings; with 2026 merit cycles ~3.5% (Mercer), equivalents run a notch higher (median ~\$124k, top ~\$135–140k). Do **not** cite the generic Arkansas figures — a recruiter would use them against you.

The ask

1. **Base** → **\$130,000** (anchor at \$135k, the midpoint). Backed three ways: the recruiter’s own 40–50% zone, employer filings + levels.fyi (\$129–134k), and a 2026 uplift on top. → with 15% + \$50k stock = **~\$199.5k total**.
2. **Relocation / sign-on** — they’re asking *you* to move, so it’s their cost to carry. Push for the higher lump-sum tier (~\$10–20k+) and/or a sign-on. Easiest “yes” — one-time money, doesn’t touch the salary band.
3. **Fallback if base is capped:** route the gap into a larger sign-on, or move the bonus target to **18–20%** (Comparably backs ~18%).
- Leave the \$50k equity alone** — it’s already above market; don’t let them rebalance base into stock.

Leverage (use it calmly — you’re not desperate)

- Stable role at Walmart Data Ventures + active competing processes (BCG X, Walmart Principal DA). You can walk.
- **They’re asking you to relocate** — that justifies both a stronger base and a real relo/sign-on.
- Already inside the Walmart ecosystem (Wibey/Claude Code) — zero ramp, lower risk for them.
- **HM-initiated fast-track** — they came to you. After you state your number, it’s fine to sit in silence.

Rebuttal cheat-sheet (for the call)

If they say:	"The band / level is capped, I can't go to \$130k."
You say:	"I hear you. You mentioned you typically hire 40–50% into the range — on a \$90–180k band that's \$126–135k, and I'm asking for \$130k, right in that zone. If the base truly can't move, can we close the gap with a sign-on or a higher bonus target?"
If they say:	"The equity makes up for the lower base."
You say:	"I appreciate the equity — it's a real strength and I'm glad it's there. But it vests over four years and carries market risk, while base is guaranteed and drives my bonus and future raises. I'd like the base to reflect the market for DS III, and keep the equity as-is."
If they say:	"\$115k is competitive for the area."
You say:	"For this role and level specifically, Walmart's own DOL filings put the median base around \$120k with several at \$130–135k, and levels.fyi has L3 base near \$130k+. \$115k sits below even the local 25th percentile. \$130k just lines me up with the middle of the market."
If they say:	"What would make you say yes today?"
You say:	"Base at \$130k, the 15% bonus and \$50k equity as offered, and a relocation package for the move. Get me there and I'm ready to sign."
If they say:	"Let me check and get back to you."
You say:	"Thanks — that's great. So we're aligned on what you're taking back: base \$130k, relo/sign-on for the move, equity and bonus as-is. What's a good timeline to reconnect?" (Pin the ask + a date.)
If they say:	On relocation specifically
You say:	"Since the role means moving to Bentonville, what does the relocation package look like — is it a lump sum, and which tier? I'd want that and/or a sign-on to cover the move."

Draft counter email

Subject: Re: Sam's Club Data Scientist III — Offer

Hi [Recruiter],

Thanks again for this — I'm excited about the team and the problems the role is pointed at, and I'd love to make it work.

Two things I wanted to talk through. First, the base. You mentioned you typically bring people in around 40–50% into the range — for the \$90–180k band, that's roughly \$126–135k. The current \$115k base sits a bit below that, and external market data (Walmart's own DOL/LCA filings and levels.fyi, both pointing to a \$130k+ median for DS III) lines up with the same picture. Given that I'm already inside the Walmart ecosystem and can ramp without a learning curve, I'd ask that we move the **base to \$130,000**, keeping the equity and bonus target as offered.

Second, since the role involves relocating to Bentonville, I'd want to make sure there's a **relocation package and/or sign-on** to cover the move. Happy to talk through what that typically looks like.

The equity package is strong and I'm glad it's part of this — I'd just like the guaranteed base and the move to line up with the market and the value I'll bring on day one. If we can get there, I'm ready to move forward quickly.

Happy to hop on a call if that's easier. Thanks for advocating for me here.

Best,
Kanu

Sources: H1B/DOL LCA filings · Levels.fyi (Walmart L3 DS) · Glassdoor (Bentonville DS; Sam's Club DS) · Comparably (Sam's Club DS) · Mercer 2026 salary-budget forecast.